

Lesson 17: The Law of Tithing and the Law of the Fast (See L17 [Class Member Study Guide](#))

Purpose: To help strengthen our desire to pay a full tithe and live the law of the fast.

1. The Lord commanded us to pay tithing and promised great blessings to those who do.

- D&C 119:1-7. One-tenth “of all their interest annually.” †1. The First Presidency †2. Pres. Joseph Fielding Smith
- Malachi 3:8-9 or 3 Nephi 24:8-9. “Will a man rob God?”

In what ways do we “rob God” if we do not pay tithes and offerings? (See D&C 104:14)

- Malachi 3:10-12 or 3 Nephi 24:10-12. Prove “me now herewith ... if I will not open you the windows of heaven”.
- What does the Lord promise those who pay tithing? †3. Elder John A. Widstoe †4. Elder Dallin H. Oaks

Reasons for paying tithing

1. Because we love the Lord. (See Moro. 7:5-9; 1 Chr. 29:9; 2 Ne. 12:24; Richards; Brockbank; Cannon on pp. 3-4.)
How does paying tithing show our love for the Lord? How does it affect our relationship with Him?

2. Because we have faith in the Lord. †5. Elder Joseph B. Wirthlin

How is tithing more to do about faith than money?

Why is it sometimes a challenge to pay tithing? How can we overcome that challenge?

Use of tithing funds

- D&C 120. Tithing “shall be disposed by a council, composed of the First Presidency of my Church ...”

†6. President Gordon B. Hinckley

What are tithing funds used for? †7. Elder Dallin H. Oaks

Reflect “on Elder Oak’s statement and consider how [you] have been blessed because of temples, meetinghouses, missionary work, the scriptures, the word to redeem the dead, and seminary or institute. [Note] that the greatest blessings we can receive are tied directly to obedience to the law of tithing. As we ponder these blessings, we can see that the Lord truly does ‘open ... the windows of heaven, and pour ... out a blessing, that there shall not be room enough to receive it’” (Malachi 3:10) (*Lesson Manual*)

2. The Lord has commanded us to fast and to pay generous fast offerings.

Another law “the Lord has restored in the latter days is the law of the fast. In obedience to this law, we fast as a Church once each month, usually on the first Sunday of the month. We are instructed that a proper fast day observance includes abstaining from food and drink for two consecutive meals and attending fast and testimony meeting... [We] may fast for reasonable amounts of time whenever we feel a special need to do so.

Fasting “is more than simply going without food. Fasting can be a joyful experience when we fast with a purpose, prepare for the fast, and pray.” (*Lesson Manual*)

Purpose Preparation Prayer

What are some purposes for fasting? What are some things we can do to prepare to fast?

* We should pray at the beginning of a fast, during the fast, and at the end of the fast.

Why is it important to pray when we fast?

- D&C 59:13-16 and Matt. 6:16-18. Why do you think fasting is equated with joy and rejoicing?

On “fast Sunday, a proper fast includes giving a generous fast offering to help care for those in need. Fast offerings are first used to help those in the ward and stake where the members reside. Bishops may use these funds to provide food, shelter, clothing, and other life-sustaining aid to those in need.” (*Lesson Manual*)

How generous should we be when we pay fast offerings? †8. President Spencer W. Kimball

What are some of the consequences when we pay generous fast offerings? (See [Isaiah 58:6-7](#))

†9. President Gordon B. Hinckley

- [Isaiah 58:8-12](#). What has the Lord promised to those who obey the law of the fast?

In what ways has fasting helped you?

What can we do to become more diligent in living the law of the fast?

Next Week: Lesson 18: “Establish ... a House of God”; See L18 [Class Member Study Guide](#). † •
(You can download a free LDS Institute manual at: [Doctrine and Covenants Manual: Religion 324 and 325](#).)

†1. **The First Presidency:** “The simplest statement we know of is the statement of the Lord himself, namely, that the members of the Church should pay ‘one-tenth of all their interest annually,’ which is understood to mean income. No one is justified in making any other statement than this” (First Presidency letter, 19 Mar. 1970).

†2. **President Joseph Fielding Smith:** “It is remarkable how many excuses can be made and interpretations given as to what constitutes the tenth... It is written, however, that as we measure it shall be measured to us again. If we are stingy with the Lord, he may be stingy with us, or in other words, withhold his blessings” (*Church History and Modern Revelation*, 2 vols. [1952], 2:92).

†3. **Elder John A. Widstoe:** “The tithe-payer establishes communion with the Lord. This is the happiest reward. Obedience to the law of tithing, as to any other law, brings a deep, inward joy, a satisfaction and understanding that can be won in no other way. Man becomes in a real sense a partner, albeit a humble one, with the Lord in the tremendous, eternal program laid out for human salvation. The principles of truth become clearer of comprehension; the living of them easier of accomplishment. A new nearness is established between man and his Maker. Prayer becomes easier. Doubt retreats; faith advances; certainty and courage buoy up the soul. The spiritual sense is sharpened; the eternal voice is heard more clearly. Man becomes more like his Father in Heaven” (in *Deseret News*, 16 May 1936, Church Section, 5).

†4. **Elder Dallin H. Oaks:** “During World War II, my widowed mother supported her three young children on a schoolteacher’s salary that was meager. When I became conscious that we went without some desirable things because we didn’t have enough money, I asked my mother why she paid so much of her salary as tithing. I have never forgotten her explanation: ‘Dallin, there might be some people who can get along without paying tithing, but we can’t. The Lord has chosen to take your father and leave me to raise you children. I cannot do that without the blessings of the Lord, and I obtain those blessings by paying an honest tithing. When I pay my tithing, I have the Lord’s promise that he will bless us, and we must have those blessings if we are to get along’” (“[Tithing](#),” *Ensign*, May 1994, 33).

†5. **Elder Joseph B. Wirthlin** said, “the payment of tithing has less to do with money, but more to do with faith” (“[Personal Integrity](#),” *Ensign*, May 1990, 32).

†6. **President Gordon B. Hinckley:** “I keep on the credenza behind my desk a widow’s mite that was given me in Jerusalem many years ago as a reminder, a constant reminder, of the sanctity of the funds with which we have to deal. They come from the widow; they are her offering as well as the tithe of the rich man, and they are to be used with care and discretion for the purposes of the Lord. We treat them carefully and safeguard them and try in every way that we can to see that they are used as we feel the Lord would have them used for the upbuilding of His work and the betterment of people” (“[This Thing Was Not Done in a Corner](#),” *Ensign*, Nov. 1996, 50).

†7. **Elder Dallin H. Oaks:** “[Tithing] funds are spent to build and maintain temples and houses of worship, to conduct our worldwide missionary work, to translate and publish scriptures, to provide resources to redeem the dead, to fund religious education, and to support other Church purposes selected by the designated servants of the Lord” (“[Tithing](#),” *Ensign*, May 1994, 35).

†8. **President Spencer W. Kimball:** “Sometimes we have been a bit penurious [unwilling to share] and figured that we had for breakfast one egg and that cost so many cents and then we give that to the Lord. I think that when we are affluent, as many of us are, that we ought to be very, very generous ... and give, instead of the amount we saved by our two meals of fasting, perhaps much, much more—ten times more where we are in a position to do it” (in [Conference Report](#), Apr. 1974, 184; Address given at the Welfare Services Meeting Saturday, April 6, 1974).

†9. **President Gordon B. Hinckley:** “Think ... of what would happen if the principles of fast day and the fast offering were observed throughout the world. The hungry would be fed, the naked clothed, the homeless sheltered. Our burden of taxes would be lightened. The giver would not suffer but would be blessed by his small abstinence. A new measure of concern and unselfishness would grow in the hearts of people everywhere” (“[The State of the Church](#),” *Ensign*, May 1991, 52-53).

Recommended Reading:

1. Elder Dallin H. Oaks, “[Tithing](#),” *Ensign*, May 1994, 33.
2. Sheryl Condie Kempton, “[Fasting: A Gift of Joy](#),” *Ensign*, Jan. 1978, 10. (A Catholic priest asked permission to reprint this talk in its entirety in his book on fasting.)
3. Bishop Victor L. Brown, “[A Vision of the Law of the Fast](#),” *Ensign*, Nov. 1977, 82.

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Enrichment Resources:

Readings:

1. Elder Gordon B. Hinckley, "[Tithing: An Opportunity to Prove Our Faithfulness](#)," *Ensign*, Apr. 1982, 40.

D&C 119:1-4. "the tithing of my people"

Orson F. Whitney: "The Law of Tithing was given to supersede, for the time being, a greater law known as the Law of Consecration [D&C 42:30-42], the object of which was and is to sanctify the Lord's people and 'prepare them for a place in the celestial world' [D&C 78:7]. To that end it was designed to do away with selfishness, greed, pride, envy, poverty, and all the ills that spring from such conditions. For none of these things can be admitted into the kingdom of heaven. It was to institute an order of equality and consequent unity, in which every man, employed at that for which he was best fitted, would be 'seeking the interest of his neighbor and doing all things with an eye single to the glory of God' [D&C 82:10]... A brave attempt to practice it was made by the Latter-day Saints, soon after this Church was organized. But they lacked experience, and did not completely rise to the occasion. Selfishness within, and persecution without, prevented a perfect achievement. So the Lord withdrew the Law of Consecration [see D&C 105], and gave to his people a lesser law, one easier to live, but pointing forward, like the other, to something grand and glorious in the future. That lesser law, the Law of Tithing, is a schoolmaster, a disciplinary agent, to bring the Saints eventually up to the practice of the higher law, and meanwhile to keep their hearts open for its reception when it returns. **Those who obey the Law of Tithing will be prepared to live the Law of Consecration. Those who do not obey it will not be prepared.** That is the whole thing in a nut shell." (In [Conference Report](#), Apr. 1931, pp. 65-66.)

Ted L. Gibbons: "**Among the promises the Lord has made to his tithe payers is this one: "And I will rebuke the devourer for your sakes."** (Malachi 3:11) Ponder the meaning of this promise. **What would it mean to the usefulness of your income if the Lord were to rebuke the devourer? What are the unexpected leaks that drain your bank account? What unforeseen expenses devour funds you had expected to use for anticipated expenses?"** (D&C Lesson 17 "The Law of Tithing and the Law of the Fast," a PDF lesson that can be obtained at [LDS GospelDoctrine.net](#))

Elder Gordon B. Hinckley: "There are many ways in which the Lord can bless us beyond the riches of the world. There is the great boon of health. The Lord has promised that he will rebuke the devourer for our sakes. Malachi speaks of the fruits of our ground. May not that rebuke of the devourer apply to various of our personal efforts and concerns?" ("[Tithing: An Opportunity to Prove Our Faithfulness](#)," *Ensign*, Apr. 1982, 40.)

Elder Gordon B. Hinckley: "We hear some these days who say that because of economic pressures they cannot afford to pay their tithing. I recall an experience I had as a stake president some years ago. A man whom I knew came to get his temple recommend signed. I questioned him in the usual way and asked, among other things, whether he was paying an honest tithing. He candidly replied that he was not, that he could not afford to because of his many debts. I felt impressed to tell him that he would not pay his debts until he paid his tithing.

"He went along for a year or two in his normal way, and then made a decision. He talked about it some time later and he said: 'What you told me has proved to be true. I felt I could not pay my tithing because of my debts. I discovered that no matter how hard I tried, somehow I could not manage to reduce my debt. Finally my wife and I sat down together and talked about it and concluded he would try the promise of the Lord. We have done so. And somehow in a way we can't quite understand, the Lord has blessed us. We have not missed that which we have given to him, and for the first time in many years we are reducing our debt. We have come to the wisdom of budgeting our expenditures and of determining where our funds have been going. Because we now have a higher objective, we are able to curtail some of our appetites and desires. And above all of this, we feel we can now to the house of the Lord with clear consciences as those deserving of this wonderful blessing.'" ("[Tithing: An Opportunity to Prove Our Faithfulness](#)," *Ensign*, Apr. 1982, 40.)

Elder Stephen L. Richards: "Every man who pays his tithing should enjoy it. The Gospel of Christ is a gospel of enjoyment. 'Man is that he may have joy.' When one pays his tithing without enjoyment he is robbed of a part of the blessing. He must learn to give cheerfully, willingly and joyfully, and his gift shall be blessed. In order that he may receive more enjoyment he needs to pay more frequently. Why deprive oneself of the joy that comes from this voluntary giving until the end of the year, when by payments throughout the year we may increase and enhance not only the joy of our giving but the practice of it." (In [Conference Report](#), Apr. 1929, 53.)

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Elder Bernard P. Brockbank: “I recall a personal experience. A few years ago when my wife and I were a young family, we were struggling to meet our financial needs, and we were in debt, and we were not honest in our payment of tithes and offerings. We were attending church and I thought that we loved the Lord, but one day my wife said to me, ‘Do you love God?’ and I answered, ‘Yes.’

“She said, ‘Do you love God as much as you love the grocer?’

“I replied, ‘I hope that I love him more than the grocer.’

“She said, ‘But you paid the grocer. Do you love God as much as the landlord? You paid him, didn’t you?’ She then said, ‘The first and great commandment is to love God, and you know we have not paid our tithing.’

“We repented and paid our tithes and offerings, and the Lord opened the windows of heaven and poured out blessings upon us. We consider it a great privilege to pay tithes and offerings to the Lord.” (In [Conference Report](#), Apr. 1971, 113-114.)

Elder Sylvester Q. Cannon: “Wholehearted obedience to the principle of tithing inculcates in man the spirit of unselfishness. It promotes the spirit of church and community welfare. It encourages fair dealing, for if a man is true in his obligations toward God, he cannot be otherwise than straightforward in his dealings with his fellow man. It helps to cultivate economy and living within our means. Thus we may gain material happiness. I think it was Benjamin Franklin who declared that there are two ways to be happy. One is to increase your income and the other is to diminish your expenses. Either one will promote happiness. It has been said that the first lesson in the art of being happy is to learn to do without and like it. I want to testify to you that that is true with regard to this, as well as with regard to every other principle of the gospel. Training in moderate self-denial is important to every human being, so that we may learn to control our appetites and our improper desires. Therein is strength and power. In like manner the principle of fasting and fast donations promotes the spirit of humility, charity, and equality in the hearts of those who observe it. Surely if there is a principle upon which the stability of any civilization rests, it is that of mutual consideration among the members thereof. Pride and high-mindedness have been a fruitful source of destruction in nations of the past.” (In [Conference Report](#), October 1929, 46.)

D&C 59:13-16. “That Thy Fasting May Be Perfect”

President Joseph F. Smith: “Now, while the law requires the Saints in all the world to fast from ‘even to even’ and to abstain both from food and drink, it can easily be seen from the Scriptures, and especially from the words of Jesus, that it is more important to obtain the true spirit of love for God and man, ‘purity of heart and simplicity of intention,’ than it is to carry out the cold letter of the law. The Lord has instituted the fast on a reasonable and intelligent basis, and none of his works are vain or otherwise. Hence, those who can are required to comply thereto; it is a duty from which they cannot escape; but let it be remembered that the observance of the fast day by abstaining twenty-four hours from food and drink is not an absolute rule, it is no iron-clad law to us, but it is left with the people as a matter of conscience, to exercise wisdom and discretion. Many are subject to weakness, others are delicate in health, and others have nursing babies; of such it should not be required to fast. Neither should parents compel their little children to fast. I have known children to cry for something to eat on fast day. In such cases, going without food will do them no good. Instead, they dread the day to come, and in place of hailing it, dislike it; while the compulsion engenders a spirit of rebellion in them, rather than a love for the Lord and their fellows. Better teach them the principle, and let them observe it when they are old enough to choose intelligently, than to so compel them.

“But those should fast who can, and all classes among us should be taught to save the meals which they would eat, or their equivalent for the poor. None are exempt from this; it is required of the Saints, old and young, in every part of the Church. It is no excuse that in some places there are no poor. In such cases the fast donation should be forwarded to the proper authorities for transmission to such stakes of Zion as may stand in need.” (*Gospel Doctrine*, pp. 243-44. Cited in *LDS Institute Manual*, 127)

Sheryl Condie Kempton: “A year ago I decided it was time for me to get back into the pattern of regular fasting. With my new resolve, I also wanted to try to learn how to make my fasts more meaningful: more acceptable to the Lord and more powerful in expanding my own spirituality...

“With all this in mind, I fasted. The first time I fasted and prayed that I might withstand a particular temptation that had been bothering me. The results were miraculous. Not only did I withstand the temptation, but it ceased to be a temptation! Not only did I resist the sin, but I did not want to sin. And so I was immediately blessed.” (“[Fasting: A Gift of Joy](#),” *Ensign*, Jan. 1978, 10. (Thomas Ryan, a Catholic priest asked permission to reprint this talk in his book on fasting.)

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